



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of the Incarnation
School Website: <https://chestertontn.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of the Incarnation (CAI) in Franklin, Tennessee presents a robust classical-Catholic educational model. Public materials consistently foreground Catholic identity, daily liturgical life, and a theology-infused, liberal-arts curriculum shaped by Great Books and the Great Conversation. The pedagogy includes Socratic discourse, memory work, and formation through imitation, with a faculty that is presented as living exemplars of virtue and scholarship. There is explicit attention to parent and community involvement through open houses, information nights, and community events. On balance, CAI aligns strongly with the Six Essential Elements of Classical Education, earning an overall CLASSICAL ranking across the six categories.

Overall categorization by rubric - Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL - Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL - Element 3 (Curriculum): CLASSICAL - Element 4 (Pedagogy): CLASSICAL - Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL - Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL

Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL

Key takeaways - CAI foregrounds transcendental aims and Catholic formation (truth, goodness, beauty) through liturgy, catechesis, and daily Mass, which maps to the Positive Keywords around religious/metaphysical foundations. - The school's stated mission emphasizes formation, virtue, and wisdom, with Great Books and a liberal-arts core (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a historically Western-Catholic curriculum. - Pedagogy features Socratic dialogue, memory work, and a conscious emphasis on contemplative elements (Scholé) alongside rigorous discussion and rhetoric. - The faculty is presented as a central, virtuous element of the curriculum (the living curriculum), with explicit references to Catholic formation and fidelity to Magisterium. - Parent and community engagement is evident via open houses, info nights, and fundraising/community activities, signaling a partnership orientation consistent with classical catechesis and culture.

What would move the needle - No major needle-moving changes are required given the CLASSICAL classification. If desired, focus could be on explicitly documenting every curricular connection to the Great Books and the Quadrivium (where not already explicit in public materials) and on providing more explicit, public statements about parent formation and co-teaching partnerships beyond event-based engagement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CAI situates Catholic identity at the center of daily life, including daily Mass to begin each school day, and explicit statements that Catholic theology is integrated into every subject. Materials also reference adoration opportunities, pilgrimages/retreats, and sacred decor within classrooms. The Open Life section emphasizes Catholic identity and the role of clergy and Magisterium in formation. - Additional public content notes that faculty vow fidelity to the Magisterium, and that church and sacramental life (Mass, confession, retreats) are integral to formation. - The school's communications emphasize faith embedded in curriculum, sacred art, and liturgical life as standard practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Catholic Identity, Daily Mass, Catholic theology integrated into subjects, Adoration, Pilgrimages/Retreats, Sacred art, Liturgical calendar integration, Oath of Fidelity, Chaplains. - Negative indicators: None evident in provided public materials (no references to secular/neutral ethics or value-neutral schooling in this domain).

Why this rating - The materials display a robust Catholic/metaphysical foundation, with concrete liturgical life and theology-infused pedagogy, aligning strongly with the Positive Keywords around religious foundations (truth/goodness/beauty as transcendentals, liturgy, sacred life, catechesis). The absence of explicit secular-relativist signals supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Cited sources - Open Life / Religion and Community sections detailing daily Mass, Catholic identity, liturgy, and sacraments. - Faculty statements and fidelity to Magisterium language. - Curricular integration of Catholic theology and sacred life themes.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials articulate formation as the aim of education, prioritizing virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing over mere job preparation. The School's tagline "High School with a Higher Purpose" explicitly frames formation and fidelity to Catholic tradition as the primary telos. - The school describes its classical, integrated education as aiming to form students in accordance with truth, goodness, and beauty, consistent with the classical-pedagogical ideal of formation rather than information alone. The Great Conversation and Great Books framework is invoked through curriculum outlines. - Foundational statements emphasize "formation" of character, virtue, and a classical liberal-arts orientation rather than solely workforce readiness.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, great conversation, true/good/beautiful, liberal education, classical mission. - Negative indicators: Explicit workforce-preparation language (college/career readiness as the sole or primary goal) is not present in public CAI materials; the public material emphasizes formation and virtue rather than job training.

Why this rating - CAI's mission statements, framing of education as formation, and emphasis on virtue and wisdom align with CLASSICAL criteria for purpose and goal (transcendent telos, formation over information, pursuit of truth/beauty). The presence of Great Books and Great Conversation language further strengthens this category.

Cited sources - "High School with a Higher Purpose" and statement of formation as the goal. - Curriculum framing around Great Books, liberal education, and formation via classical methods.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The humanities curriculum is described as braided across history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages with an integrated approach and use of the Socratic Method. - The curriculum explicitly foregrounds the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium components are referenced in the broader classical lexicon and Great Books framework) and the Great Books tradition—Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton, Canterbury Tales, etc.—as part of a direct aim to join the Great Conversation. - Course progression and content emphasize history across periods (Ancient World through Modern World), philosophy, theology, and languages, with explicit cross-disciplinary integration. The program includes classical art, music, drama, and literature as integral to the curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books, Great Conversation, primary sources/original texts, history as Western civilization, interdisciplinary integration, contemplation/wonder, sacred/tradition-based content (theological foundations). - Negative indicators: Public materials do not emphasize social-studies-centric framing, project-based learning as dominant; the emphasis is on classical, canonical works and structured memory/recitation when appropriate.

Why this rating - CAI's curriculum is coherently classical: liberal-arts foundation, Great Books emphasis, integrated, cross-disciplinary approach, and explicit emphasis on formal study of history and philosophy in conjunction with theology. The explicit reference to the Great Conversation and primary texts strengthens the CLASSICAL rating.

Cited sources - Curriculum page describing integrated humanities and Socratic method. - Humanities progression (history, literature, philosophy, theology, languages) and emphasis on classical texts. - Specific program details (science and fine arts as part of liberal-arts education) illustrating breadth within a liberal-arts frame.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials explicitly describe Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates in upper grades, with students trained in rhetoric and opportunities to give speeches. The public curriculum outlines reference Socratic method in humanities and integrated discussion across subjects. - Lower-school pedagogy references singing, chanting, and memory work as part of the learning process (memory-centered pedagogy), aligning with traditional pedagogy in classical education. The chant/memory work is echoed in the "Six Essential Elements" lexicon as memorization/recitation strategies. - The school emphasizes contemplative/restful learning (Scholé) alongside rigorous inquiry, indicating a balanced approach to pedagogy that preserves contemplative time. - There are explicit references to the life of learning through art, drama, and public speaking; the headmaster and faculty emphasize the cultivation of virtue and mastery in rhetoric.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Socratic seminar, dialectic, great conversation, rhetoric, memory work/recitation, chorale/chanting for memorization, contemplative/restful learning (Scholé), formation through imitation. - Negative indicators: Public materials do not emphasize exclusive project-based/experiential-only approaches; the dominant pedagogy remains classical (not anti-classical).

Why this rating - CAI's pedagogy aligns with classical practices: Socratic inquiry, rhetoric, memory work, and structured practice, combined with contemplative pedagogy and formation via imitation, fit the CLASSICAL rubric well.

Cited sources - Curriculum page with Socratic method and integrated humanities pedagogy. - Explicit mention of singing/chanting/memory in the broader CAI materials (as part of classical pedagogy). - References to Scholé and contemplative pace. - Headmaster/faculty notes on rhetoric and public-speaking training.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is described as faithful to Catholic formation and as the living curriculum, with a "faithful faculty" section highlighting faculty as moral exemplars and a core of the school. The headmaster profile emphasizes deep formation and experience in the classical-schools movement. - The public materials emphasize a strong governance by a board of parents/educators and recruitment of classical teachers from local and national networks, with the faculty taking an oath of fidelity to the Magisterium. The faculty are presented as mentors and models of virtue. - Public statements describe the faculty as the "living curriculum" and as partners with students in forming character and intellect.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: living curriculum, faithful faculty, oath of fidelity, mentorship and virtue exemplars, master-teacher model, collegial culture, teacher formation in classical pedagogy. - Negative indicators: None evident in public materials; no explicit statements about non-classical or anti-classical faculty development.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly embody classical norms of faculty as models of virtue and scholarship, central to the school's identity and pedagogy, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.

Cited sources - Public "Faithful Faculty" section and bios. - Headmaster profile and Magisterium fidelity language. - Description of faculty as living curriculum.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school actively communicates with families through information nights, open houses, and community events. The presence of Open House events, Info Night events, and newsletters indicates ongoing parent engagement and a pathway for families to participate publicly in the school's classical culture. - Fall Open Houses and Chesterton Academy info nights (public-facing) signal partnership with families and opportunities for parents to engage with the curricular and philosophical aims of classical education. - The school maintains a culture of community involvement through events like Giving Day, Gala fundraising, and parent/board leadership, illustrating an engaged school community and opportunities for parents to participate as co-educators and supporters.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with families, open campus, family engagement, parent formation via events (open houses, info nights), community leadership, shared mission. - Negative indicators: None evident in public materials; no consumer/customer-service framing; events point toward partnership rather than commodification.

Why this rating - CAI's communications emphasize parent involvement and community integration that align with classical ideals of parent partnership and shared formation. This maps to the Positive Keywords and supports a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Cited sources - Open houses and info nights signaling family engagement. - Fall Open Houses and public communications about events. - Giving Day and community fundraising with parent/board involvement.

What Would Move the Needle

- While CAI is CLASSICAL across all six categories, explicit public articulations of a few items could strengthen the alignment further:
 - Publicly enumerate the Great Books list and clearly map each course to the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium components, including explicit references to Latin and classical languages in more places on the site.
 - More explicit, public statements about parent formation roles (co-teaching, home-school partnerships, or family catechesis) beyond event-based engagement, framed within the "Partnership with Families" vocabulary from the Six Essential Elements.
 - Provide a public-facing justification of the Great Conversation framework, detailing how Western canonical texts frame the junior-senior curriculum and how non-canonical texts are integrated (if applicable) without diluting the liberal-arts core.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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